BOOKS

The Will to Live

The riveting story of Shahbaz Taseer's abduction and five years in terrorist captivity

Five years of being abducted and held by terrorists couldn't break Shahbaz Taseer. The story he tells of his captivity is riveting, horrifying and life-affirming.

The author's late father, Salman Taseer, was the Governor of Punjab (Pakistan) and a distinguished public figure. In January 2011, he was gunned down by fundamentalists for having championed the cause of Asia Bibi, a Pakistani Christian woman accused of blasphemy.

Seven months later, in Lahore, Taseer left home for work, in his father's Mercedes two-seater coupé. Despite the terrible shadow cast by the assassination, the young man chose to dismiss his security guard. Why? Because the car's cramped interior would have made it uncomfortable. When five gun-toting masked men forced him to stop, his first thought was that they were carjackers. He dropped the car keys into the door panel, hoping to thwart them.

He was hooded, beaten and taken to a tiny, stinking chamber where he was dosed repeatedly with ketamine, a horse tranquiliser. "If I had known," writes Taseer, "on that very first day, that I would spend the next four and a half years of my life in captivity, I do not think I would have made it. The one consolation of my first few days was that I believed that my ordeal would soon be over."

Early in the book, Taseer provides a brief family history in which he is unsparingly honest about himself. "I'd been living in a bubble," he writes of his pre-abduction life. He was recently married, a 30-year-old western-educated businessman, insulated from the medieval politics of his native land by his privileged upbringing.

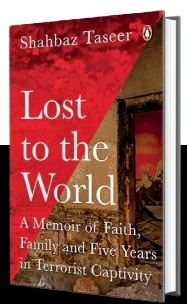
He idolised his father, but appeared not to share the same intense commitment to social issues. Even as he was being whisked away, he focused on the car, the keys, the Bulgari watch on his wrist. In the long run, however, these seemingly frivolous fixations ensured Taseer's long-term survival. The abandoned car led investigators to the kidnappers. The watch, miraculously, became a crucial bargaining chip.

For much of his ordeal, Taseer was starved, chained and tortured. He had no idea about the efforts his family was making to find him. He was shuffled from place to place, sometimes in women's clothes to avoid being recognised. He was smuggled into Afghanistan, was almost blown to bits in the fighting, before being thrown into a Taliban prison. Luck, bravery and strength of mind: these were the tools with which he finally escaped.

Two exceptional women emerge from the narrative. One is his mother, Aamna Taseer, who defied the kidnappers even when forced to hear her son's screams over the cellphone. The other was the lead captor's mother-in-law. A large-hearted matriarch, she halted the torment when the captive was at his lowest ebb.

Taseer's greatest asset is that he delivers his story without self-pity or bombast. Echoing through the book is Taseer's father's motto: I am not made from a wood that burns easily. The same is true of his son. ■

Manjula Padmanabhan

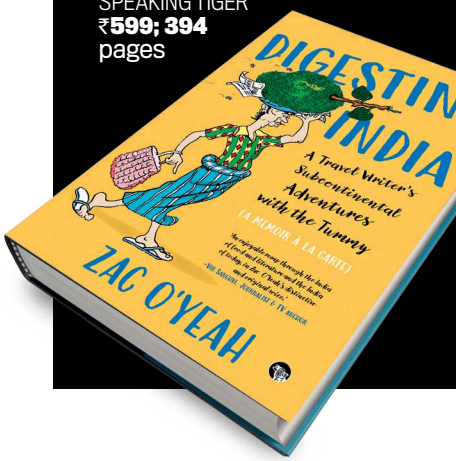


LOST TO THE WORLD: A Memoir of Faith, Family and Five Years in Terrorist Captivity
by Shahbaz Taseer
PENGUIN
₹599; 296 pages

TRAVELS WITH THE TUMMY

***Zac O'Yeah**'s travel-cum-food memoir is a distillation of eating his way through India over three decades*

DIGESTING INDIA: A Travel Writer's Subcontinental Adventures with the Tummy
by Zac O'Yeah
SPEAKING TIGER
₹599; 394 pages



The pressure cooker was not amused. In the short story 'Rules for Drivers', the writer Santhosh Aechikkanam tells you that "the cooker was female". It's a detail that baffles Ravichandran, philosopher and writer, who has been abandoned to fend for himself after a slight altercation with his wife Akhila, leaving him with a league of enraged kitchen gadgets and utensils.

In J. Devika's vibrant encounters of the Kerala kind—her selection of short stories translated by her from the Malayalam into English—the protagonist is most often a woman. On the jacket, Devika is described as a "feminist historian, social researcher and translator,